



The HCL Beanstalk 4458's keyboard offers several shortcut buttons

every type of control in the form of extra shortcut buttons, ranging from audio controls to Web surfing and page navigation controls.

Package contents: Finally, we evaluated the software, the documentation and the manuals that accompanied the system. Here, the Vintron

systems stood out—they included Norton AntiVirus 2000 6.0, McAfee 5.0, Satyam 100-hour Internet Pack, Eudora 5.1, Pegasus Mail 3.1, and trial versions of Front Page 98 and Dreamweaver 4. Also included were utilities such as Winamp 2.7 and Real Player 8. The Visualan Wisdom, with its ATi Rage Pro 128 graphics card, brought along PowerDVD 3.0 and *4x4 Evolution*, a racing game. The Compaq Presario 3705AP also included a good set of software: Norton 2002, Money 2002, Encarta Encyclopedia 2002, Norton Security 2002, Microsoft Works 6.0 along with a 30-hour Satyam Internet package. It also had Windows XP Home Edition loaded and the appropriate CD was also provided.

The Dart Emerald also had a good set of bundled goodies, which included an HCL InfiNet 45-day Internet pack, Simon & Schuster Millennium Encyclopedia, four games (*Odium*, *Septerra Core*, *Claw* and *Shogo*) along with three other entertainment and multimedia CDs. It also had a recovery CD to restore the OS to its factory condition.

Both the HCL machines came loaded with Windows XP Home Edition and the Plus! Pack loaded; they too had CDs to restore

HCL Beanstalk 4458

This black beauty from HCL boasts a good configuration with a very appealing design. A 2 GHz Pentium 4 processor on an Intel 845GL motherboard defines new highs in multimedia entertainment and learning. It comes with a 17-

inch flat monitor and a powerful Altec Lansing 2.1 speaker system.

The 128 MB of DDR RAM and onboard graphics ensure reasonably smooth 3D gaming and movies, and the 40 GB hard disk suits most general applications that do not need excessive storage. The appeal of this system lies in the optical mouse and the functional keyboard that boasts of an assortment of shortcut keys for everything from editing text, to browser control and quick access to your media files. On the expansion front, it can support up to 6 GB of memory but has only two free PCI slots. With four USB ports, you can easily connect devices such as a Web camera, scanner, printer, etc.

This computer represents a good out-of-the-box experience for customers. It comes bundled with XP Plus for Win-

dows and a host of other system applications and utilities—all at a price of Rs 48,990.

Suitability to Task Index	
Gaming	6.32
Productivity	6.49
Office apps/Internet	6.25

the operating system to the original factory condition. The only two computers that were loaded with Windows XP Professional were the PCS Oriion and the Zenith Premium Corporate PC. The PCS Oriion bundled Britannica Encyclopedia with a CD of utilities, one for teaching Internet basics and Web design and one with an assortment of MP3 songs. The Zenith Premium Corporate PC bundled Norton Internet Security Software, Norton



The Zenith PC has two USB ports on the front panel

AntiVirus 2002 (three months of free virus update subscription) and NTI CD Maker along with a few freeware utilities.

The only system that came loaded with Windows 98 SE was the Visualan Celebrity. It included software such as CD Ghost, Genesys, Language Genius, Media Ring Talk, PC-Cillin Antivirus, PC DJ, Recovery Genius and Super Voice along with a few freeware utilities. A system that really skimped on software was the QMAX Quadrant. It included only a 100-hour Satyam Internet package along with the Windows XP Home Edition CD.

All the computers we received had driver CDs and contained the manuals and documentation that explained the functioning of the system and how to set it up.

Performance tests

Performance was evaluated using an assortment of real world and synthetic applications. To help evaluate the suitability of the various systems to specific application areas, we also created Suitability To Task Indexes for measuring their performance in three target application areas—gaming and entertainment, productivity, and office and Internet applications. This was done by allotting varying weightages to each benchmark depending on the application area.

Gaming and entertainment: Here, we specifically observed the performance of the computers in the gaming, monitor performance, audio encoding, speakers, CD-ROM and soundcard tests.

The computer that excelled in this application area was the Visualan Lavish. With its ATi Radeon 7500 graphics card, a fast 2.53 GHz Pen-

tium 4 processor, 256 MB of DDR memory and a 40 GB, 7,200-rpm Seagate Barracuda hard disk, the PC excelled in gaming and applications involving work with audio and video. In the gaming tests, it pumped out a commendable 74 fps when running the *Quake III* test at a resolution of 1024x768 and in the *Evolva* test, it churned out 50.5 fps.

It delivered a best-of-class score in raw processing, thanks to its 2.53 GHz Pentium 4 processor. Similarly, it performed well in the hard disk and the memory tests due to the fast 7,200-rpm hard disk and DDR RAM, logging 41 MBps in the sequential read/write tests for the hard disk and a shade over 2 GBps in the memory bandwidth tests. When it came to the peripherals, the 17-inch LG Flatron monitor returned good clarity and colour reproduction, and the 2.1 speakers performed adequately during the audio tests. The

